

[Return to Search](#)

The structure of Kanuri society

Author(S): Cohen, Ronald

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 332

Culture (OWC): [Kanuri \(MS14\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1956-1957

Coverage Date: 1956-1957

Place Coverage: Magumeri, Borno State, Nigeria

Section Title(S): Chapter X Summary And Conclusions

However, the Bornu Emirate under the British was not the same article as its 19th century predecessor. Its boundaries were now permanently delimited and required no great responsibility on the part of the local people to defend or expand. The military power of the Shehu and control of "foreign affairs" with other Sudanic military powers had now been taken over by the British, who performed these functions in accordance with the imperial policies of the colonial government of England. Indeed the need for militarism all but vanished since the Bornu political organization and territory were now dependent upon the position and policy of Great Britain in world affairs.

178
[Sociocultural Trends](#)

642
[Form And Rules Of Government](#)

648
[External Relations](#)

The policies of indirect rule created a climate of control wherein the previous cultural life could continue; however, because of the intrusion of the British administration into the top of the society as a controlling caste who were supposed to rule through local authorities, there occurred a potential weakening of the indigenous political organization. Although a high degree of integration of law, religion and social organization remained, and all functioned to support authority, there were no other authorities at the top of Kanuri society. Unlike the authorities in the traditional society, the British had different values and goals. Because both traditional standards of performance and goals and the new ones are both enforceable, new conflicts have become possible in the contemporary society, especially in the political sphere.

178
[Sociocultural Trends](#)

182
[Functional/Adaptational Interpretations](#)

642
[Form And Rules Of Government](#)

648
[External Relations](#)

In order to place kinship in a larger social context, behaviour associated with kinship has been categorized under four somewhat  333 overlapping areas of norms of behavior, each of which includes kin and non-kin relationships. These are, namely, shame-avoidance (nungu), discipline-respect (b[unknown]erzum), joking (suli), and friendship (numkam). The mutual expectations accompanying these norms of behavior are the “warp and woof” of Kanuri interpersonal relations. Or to put it another way, they are the building blocks upon which the Kanuri social structure maintains itself as an ongoing system.

183
Norms

571
Social Relationships
And Groups

602
Kin Relationships

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)